

TAXPAYER FUNDING FOR REFUGEE RESETTLEMENT, HUMANITARIAN PAROLE & MIGRANT SHELTER SERVICES

Fiscal Years 2021–2026 | Figures from official U.S. government sources

What this covers — and what it does not

Congress appropriates funds to federal agencies that then grant money to states and nonprofit organizations (NGOs) for **lawful** refugee resettlement, humanitarian parolees (e.g., Afghans, Ukrainians, Cubans, Haitians, Nicaraguans, Venezuelans), asylees, and unaccompanied children, plus **shelter and services for noncitizens released from DHS custody** pending immigration proceedings. Undocumented adults are generally ineligible for federal SNAP, TANF, and regular Medicaid. Costs below mix those legal programs with local emergency shelter for recent arrivals. There is no single official line item titled “illegal invasion.”

1. HHS Office of Refugee Resettlement (ORR) — Refugee & Entrant Assistance

This account funds Refugee Cash Assistance, Refugee Medical Assistance, social services, and the Unaccompanied Alien Children (UAC) program. Peak-year totals include emergency/supplemental appropriations:

Fiscal year	Approx. budget authority available	Source
FY 2021	~\$6.17 billion (incl. transfers and supplemental)	HHS ACF Congressional Justification
FY 2022	~\$8.93 billion	HHS ACF CJ
FY 2023	~\$10.61 billion	HHS ACF CJ
FY 2024	~\$6.87 billion enacted	HHS ACF CJ
FY 2025	~\$6.4–6.7 billion range	HHS ACF CJ / CR

UAC care is the largest cost driver in peak years (hundreds of thousands of children referred). GAO: HHS received \$3.78 billion in Ukraine supplemental appropriations FY2022–24 for parolees and other eligible populations; ~135,000 Ukrainians served FY2022–24.

2. FEMA Shelter & Services (EFSP-H then SSP) — hotels, food, transport

Congress directed CBP funds to FEMA for grants to cities, states, and NGOs serving noncitizens *released from DHS custody*. DHS OIG (Apr 2026): FEMA awarded nearly **\$1.4 billion** in FY2023–24 (\$425M EFSP-H + ~\$1.0B SSP). Earlier EFSP-H appropriations totaled about \$290 million (FY2019/21/22). FY2025 continuing resolutions funded SSP at the FY2024 level of \$650 million. Combined humanitarian shelter grants since 2021 are on the order of **\$2+ billion**. Allowable uses: shelter (incl. hotels, capped share), food, medical, hygiene, limited onward transportation. FEMA guidance: grant funds may **not** be used for gift/prepaid debit cards.

3. State Department / PRM Reception & Placement

PRM funds overseas processing and initial 30–90 day Reception & Placement grants to 9–10 national resettlement NGOs (e.g., USCCB, IRC, HIAS, Church World Service, USCRI). FY2024 refugee-admissions availability was about **\$1.32 billion** (State) plus USCIS processing; combined federal refugee-processing/resettlement availability ~\$2.8 billion in FY2024 (State FY25 Report to Congress).

4. CBO on the 2021–2026 immigration surge (federal budget)

CBO (July 2024): of ~8.7 million people in the 2021–26 surge, about 35% are “qualified aliens” on arrival; ~65% are unlawfully present and ineligible for most federal benefits except emergency Medicaid and child nutrition. Participation of surge immigrants and their children adds an estimated **\$177 billion** in federal mandatory spending over 2024–2034 (Medicaid/CHIP, SNAP, EITC/CTC, child nutrition, SSI). The same population is projected to pay far more in taxes over that decade (\$1.2 trillion additional federal revenue). Net federal fiscal effect is positive in CBO’s long-run baseline; short-run local shelter costs are not fully captured there.

5. Documented local hotel / shelter costs (city funds + some federal grants)

- **New York City:** Comptroller / city figures: nearly **\$4.6 billion** on shelter and services for newly arrived migrants through May 2024. Hotel rooms under the HANYC contract averaged **\$156/night** (FY2024); all-in emergency hotel shelter ~\$332/day including services. Housing portion ~\$2.3 billion for 2023–24. A city-funded food debit-card pilot (not FEMA) gave families ~\$1,200/28 days for a family of four; program later ended.
- **Chicago:** City leaders: nearly **\$434 million** for food, shelter, and services, July 2022–July 2024 (Migration Policy Institute compilation of city figures).
- **Denver:** City reported ~\$79 million through 2024 on facilities/hotels, personnel, food, and services; regional estimates including hospitals/schools higher (~\$356 million, Common Sense Institute using city and hospital data).

6. Phones, laptops, cash cards

No comprehensive federal appropriation exists for “laptops and phones for illegal aliens.” Welcome kits and case-management items appear inside ORR/PRM/NGO grants at modest scale. FEMA SSP/EFSP-H explicitly exclude prepaid gift cards. NYC’s debit cards were a **city** pilot. Overseas, State/PRM and UN partners have used cash-and-voucher assistance for people in transit in Latin America; those programs are separate from domestic SNAP.

Eligibility note (federal means-tested benefits)

PRWORA (1996): most undocumented adults cannot receive SNAP, TANF, SSI, or non-emergency Medicaid. Refugees, asylees, and certain parolees are eligible (sometimes after a waiting period; refugees often immediately). U.S.-born children of noncitizens are citizens and may receive SNAP/Medicaid. Emergency Medicaid for labor/delivery and life-threatening conditions is available regardless of status. State-only programs in some jurisdictions go further.

Primary sources: HHS/ACF Congressional Justifications FY2023–FY2027; DHS OIG-26-04 (Apr 2026); CRS on SSP/EFSP-H; CBO, *Effects of the Immigration Surge on the Federal Budget and the Economy* (July 2024) and *state/local report* (June 2025); GAO-26-107815; State Dept. Report to Congress on Proposed Refugee Admissions FY2025; NYC Comptroller hotel-per-diem analysis. Advocacy tallies (FAIR/Heritage/CIS) omitted. Aug 2026. Not a complete all-government cost; education/ER/incarceration largely excluded.